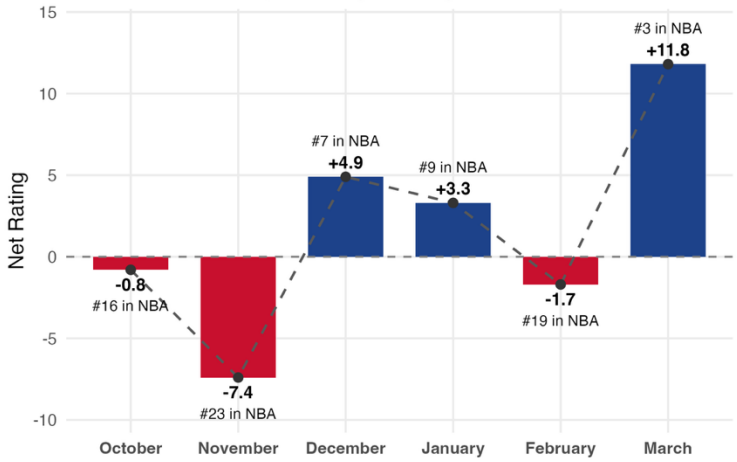
Los Angeles Clippers: Early Struggles → Contender Form

Role Stability, 2-Way Efficiency, & Lineup Context Behind the Surge

By: Gregory Lederer | All data as of 3/14/2026 per Basketball Reference, NBA.com/stats, & Spotrac

LA Clippers Net Rating by Month

Monthly net rating with league rank context



Month	REB%	TOV%	W-L
OCT	50.0	17.8	3-2
NOV	48.4	15.7	2-13
DEC	50.2	15.2	6-6
JAN	48.8	14.6	11-4
FEB	50.7	15.9	5-6
MAR	49.8	10.5	7-1

Early Season Instability → Recent Surge

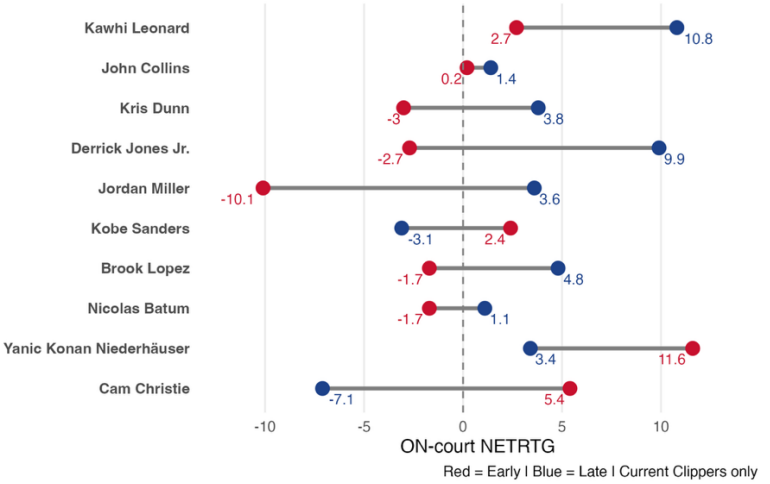
Early Season Struggles: Negative NETRTG in first 2 months while going 5–15 during that stretch. Defensively weak with a 120.5 DRTG. High TOV rates in first 2 months limited offensive efficiency despite solid rebounding.

Midseason Stabilization: Performance improved in DEC and JAN as LAC posted positive NETRTGs, going 17–10 across the 2 months. ORTG stabilized around 117, while TOVs declined to 14.6%, allowing the team to generate more consistent half-court offense.

March Breakout: LAC has surged in March with a 7–1 record and +11.8 NETRTG (#3 in the NBA). This jump has been driven by an ORTG of 126.3 and their lowest TOV rate of the season 10.5%, signaling improved offensive execution.

Personnel Behind the Surge

Clippers ON-court NETRTG by player: Early (OCT-DEC) vs Late (JAN-MAR)



Personnel Impact & Lineup Context

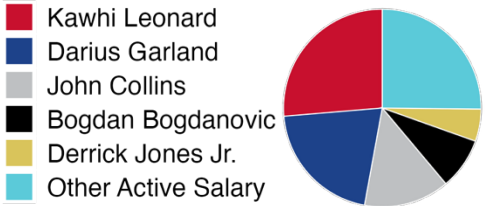
Several key rotation players saw significant improvement in their on-court impact after the first 3 months of the season. Kawhi, Derrick Jones Jr, and Brook Lopez all saw large jumps in ON-court NETRTG as their lineups stabilized, and roles became clearer. Jordan Miller also showed one of the largest improvements, reflecting stronger lineup performance during his minutes later in the season.

Period	On Court	Off Court	Difference
Ivica Zubac			
OCT-DEC	-2.0	-0.6	-1.4
JAN-MAR	1.7	-0.3	2.0
James Harden			
OCT-DEC	1.0	-6.3	7.3
JAN-MAR	0.1	8.5	-8.4

Ivica Zubac: Clear structural gap in frontcourt after his departure, but the team's underlying performance profile without him changed very little. Early in the season LAC rebounded slightly better with Zubac on the floor (50.9% REB vs 47.7% off), and that pattern held later as well (51.7% vs 48%), suggesting his primary impact came on the glass and interior presence rather than dramatically shifting overall team efficiency.

James Harden: His role early in the season was far more central to the offense. LAC's lineups with Harden posted a 57.5% AST rate and a 119.2 ORTG early in the year, reflecting how heavily the team relied on his playmaking. However, in the recent months, the offense has remained efficient without him, turnovers dropped (16.9%→13.9%), indicating that improved lineup balance and clearer offensive roles allowed the team to sustain production even after losing its primary creator.

Roster Construction & Salary Outlook

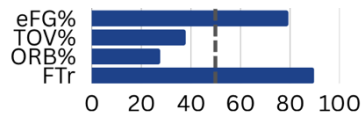


LAC's salary structure is concentrated among a small group of players, with Kawhi Leonard, Darius Garland, and John Collins accounting for a large portion of the team's committed cap space. The remaining roster is largely composed of mid-level and smaller contracts to fill out the rotation. LA is currently above the luxury tax line but below both aprons. Several rotation players are under contract through the next season, but numerous then become unrestricted free agents following the 2026-27 season (Kawhi, Collins, Bogdan, DJJ & more).

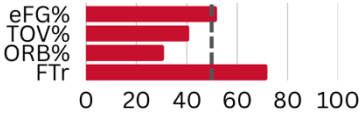
Pick Type	2026	2027	2028
1st Round	→ OKC / IND 5–9 → LAC	→ OKC	→ PHI
2nd Round	CLE → LAC	→ UTA	DAL → LAC

LAC does not control a 1st round pick through 2028, aside from a conditional IND selection in 2026 (5-9). The team does retain a few incoming 2nd round picks, providing limited draft flexibility.

Offensive Four Factors %tile



Defensive Four Factors %tile



Conclusion: Stabilization Fuels Surge

After early struggles, clearer roles and steadier rotations stabilized their performance. Kawhi's 2-way impact and improved 4 factors efficiency have driven the recent surge. With a top NETRTG in recent months, they now look like more of a contender.